

What are mammals?

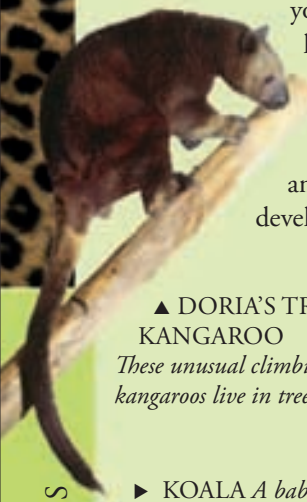
When the dinosaurs were wiped out, it gave a group of small, warm-blooded animals the chance they needed to thrive. These were the mammals, distinct from other animals largely because they feed their young on milk.

There are now around 5,000 species of mammal.

They are grouped into different families and orders, including:

MARSUPIALS

Marsupials are a group of mammals found in Australasia and the Americas. They give birth to tiny, undeveloped young. Many marsupials have a pouch. The newborn crawls into the pouch to feed on milk and complete its development.



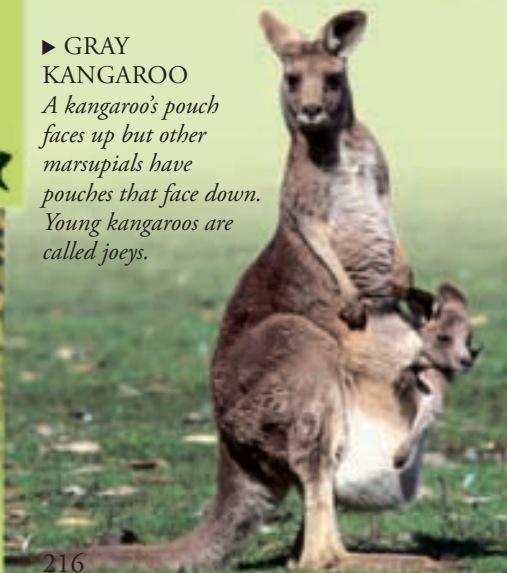
▲ DORIA'S TREE KANGAROO

These unusual climbing kangaroos live in trees.

► **KOALA** *A baby koala will spend more than six months in its mother's pouch.*



► **GRAY KANGAROO** *A kangaroo's pouch faces up but other marsupials have pouches that face down. Young kangaroos are called joeys.*



BATS

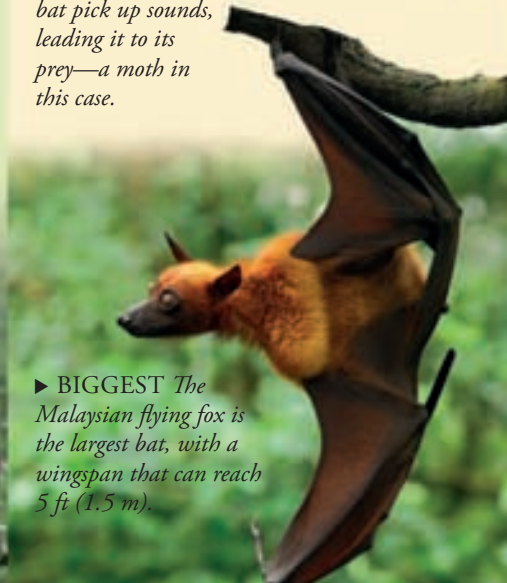
Bats are the only mammals that can fly (rather than glide). They include the world's smallest mammal, Kitti's hog-nosed bat. Their wings are formed from a double layer of skin.



◀ **SMALLEST** *Kitti's hog-nosed bat is just 1¼ in (3 cm) long.*



► **GRAY LONG-EARED BAT** *Long ears help this bat pick up sounds, leading it to its prey—a moth in this case.*



► **BIGGEST** *The Malaysian flying fox is the largest bat, with a wingspan that can reach 5 ft (1.5 m).*

RODENTS

There are more species of rodent than any other mammal. Most rodents are small and many, such as mice, have a long tail. They all have clawed feet, long whiskers, and large gnawing teeth (incisors) at the front of their mouths.



► **CAPYBARA** *This is the world's largest rodent, reaching lengths of up to 4 ft (1.3 m).*



Cape porcupine (well protected by its spines, or quills).

▼ **PRAIRIE DOGS** *live in burrows that join those of neighbors, forming "towns."*

